“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 16

Śrī Caitanya’s Longing to Go to Vṛndāvana

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Sprinkling the garden of Gauḍa with the nectar of His glances, the cloud that is Gaura revived the people — creepers scorched by the fire of worldly existence.

2 Glory, glory to Gauracandra! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 The Lord conceived the desire to go to Vṛndāvana, and when Pratāparudra heard of it, he was downcast.

4 The king summoned the two of them, Sārvabhauma and Rāmānanda, and spoke to them humbly:

5 “The Lord has a mind to leave Nīlādri and go elsewhere. Please make every effort to keep Him here.

6 Without Him this kingdom gives me no pleasure. Use every means to keep the Gosāñi here.”

7 Then the Lord took counsel with the two of them, Rāmānanda and Sārvabhauma: “I will go to Vṛndāvana.”

8 Both of them said, “See the Ratha-yātrā first; when Kārtika comes, then You may go.”

9 When Kārtika came, they said, “Now it is bitterly cold. See the Dola-yātrā and then go — that is the proper way.”

10 Saying “today, tomorrow,” they raised one pretext after another; afraid of separation, they would not consent to His going.

11 Although the Lord is independent and no one can stop Him, He would not leave without the consent of His devotees.

12 In the third year all the devotees of Gauḍa resolved to go to Nīlācala.

13 They all gathered and went to Advaita Ācārya, and the Ācārya joyfully set out to see the Lord.

14–15 Although the Lord had ordered Nityānanda Prabhu to stay in Gauḍa and reveal *prema-bhakti*, He nevertheless set out to see Mahāprabhu. Who can understand the ways of Nityānanda’s love?

16–17 Ācāryaratna, Vidyānidhi, Śrīvāsa, Rāmāi, Vāsudeva, Murāri, the three brothers Govinda and the others, and Rāghava Paṇḍita, who had packed his bags (*jhāli*) — all set out; the residents of Kulīna-grāma came bringing silk ropes.

18 Narahari of Khaṇḍa and Śrī Raghunandana came too. All the devotees set out — who can count them?

19 Śivānanda Sena settled the tolls at the crossings; taking care of everyone, he led them happily along.

20 He attended to everyone's needs and found them places to stay, for Śivānanda knew the roads through Orissa well.

21 That year all the ladies went to see the Lord. Acyuta's mother went with the Ācārya.

22 Mālinī went with Śrīvāsa Paṇḍita, and Śivānanda's wife went with him.

23 Śivānanda's son, named Caitanya dāsa, also set out joyfully to see the Lord.

24 Ācāryaratna's wife went with him. I do not know how to describe that love.

25 To offer Mahāprabhu a meal, all the ladies brought from home many of the Lord's favourite foods.

26 Śivānanda Sena arranged everything. He pacified the toll collectors (*ghāṭiyāla*) and found lodgings for everyone.

27 Everywhere he looked after them all and gave them food, and he went on in supreme bliss to see the Lord.

28 Coming to Remuṇā, they had *darśana* of Gopīnātha, and there the Ācārya sang and danced.

29 Nityānanda was known to all the people there, and the temple servants came and showed Him great honour.

30 All those great souls stayed there that night, and a servant brought twelve pots of *kṣīra* (sweet rice) and set them before them.

31 Nityānanda Prabhu divided the *kṣīra* and gave it to everyone, and receiving that *kṣīra-prasāda*, they were all filled with joy.

32 The story of Mādhava Purī, the installation of Gopāla, how Gopāla asked him for sandalwood,

33 and how Gopīnātha stole *kṣīra* for his sake — they had heard this story earlier from Mahāprabhu's own mouth.

34 Now Nityānanda told that story among them all, and the Vaiṣṇavas' hearts swelled with joy as they listened.

35 Travelling on in this way, they came to Kaṭaka. There they saw Sākṣi-gopāla and stayed that day.

36 Nityānanda told the story of Sākṣi-gopāla, and the Vaiṣṇavas' hearts swelled with joy as they listened.

37 Their hearts were all eager to meet the Lord, so they hurried on to Śrī Nīlācala.

38 Hearing that they had reached Āṭhāranālā, the Gosāñi placed two garlands in Govinda's hands and sent him to them.

39 Govinda put the two garlands on the two of them, and Advaita and the Avadhūta Gosāñi (Nityānanda) were overjoyed.

40 Right there they began Kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana, and the two of them came on, dancing all the way.

41 Then Śacī's son gave garlands to Svarūpa and His other associates and sent them ahead.

42 Coming to Narendra, they met everyone there and put on them all the garlands Mahāprabhu had given.

43 When Gaurarāya heard that they had reached the Siṁha-dvāra, the Lord came Himself and met them all.

44 Taking them all with Him, He had *darśana* of Jagannātha, and then He brought them all back to His own residence.

45 Vāṇīnātha and Kāśī Miśra brought *prasāda*, and the Lord fed everyone *prasāda* with His own hand.

46 He sent each of them to the lodging they had had the year before and let them rest.

47 In this way the devotees stayed four months, enjoying the pastimes of *kīrtana* with the Lord.

48 When the time of the Ratha-yātrā came, He took them all, as before, and washed the Guṇḍicā temple.

49 The residents of Kulīna-grāma gave silk ropes to Jagannātha, and as before He danced in front of the chariot.

50 After dancing a great deal He went to the garden, and there He rested on the bank of the pond.

51 There was a brāhmaṇa from Rāḍha, a servant of Nityānanda, most fortunate, named Kṛṣṇadāsa.

52 He filled a pitcher and bathed the Lord, and the Lord was greatly pleased with his bathing Him.

53 A great deal of *prasāda* came from the Balagaṇḍi offering, and Mahāprabhu honoured the *prasāda* with them all.

54 As before, He watched the Ratha-yātrā, and with His devotees He saw the festival of Herā-pañcamī.

55 Ācārya Gosāñi invited the Lord, and in the middle of it he brought on a storm of rain —

56 all this Vṛndāvana dāsa has described in detail. Then Śrīvāsa invited the Lord.

57 Mālinī cooked all the Lord's favourite dishes. In devotion she thought of herself as His maidservant; in affection she was His mother.

58 Ācāryaratna and the other leading devotees invited the Lord from time to time.

59 At the end of Cāturmāsya the Lord would again take Nityānanda aside every day and sit with Him in private, holding some counsel.

60 Ācārya Gosāñi spoke to the Lord in hints; the Ācārya recited riddles (*tarjā*) that no one could understand.

61 Looking at his face, Śacī's son smiled; taking this as His assent, the Ācārya began to dance.

62 Whether it was a prayer or an instruction, no one understood. Then the Lord embraced him and bade him farewell.

63 The Lord said to Nityānanda, "Listen, Śrīpāda: I beg this of You — grant Me this favour.

64 Do not come to Nīlācala every year. Stay in Gauḍa and fulfil My desire.

65 I see no one else who could accomplish it. My difficult work can be done only by You."

66 Nityānanda said, "I am the body and You are the life. Body and life are not separate — this is the proof.

67 Yet by Your inconceivable potency You bring this about. Whatever You make Me do, that I do; there is no rule here."

68 The Lord embraced Him and bade Him farewell, and in the same way He bade farewell to all the devotees.

69 As before, a resident of Kulīna-grāma submitted, "Lord, please instruct me: what is my duty, my practice?"

70 The Lord said, "Serve the Vaiṣṇavas and chant the Holy Name in *saṅkīrtana*. Do these two, and you will quickly attain the feet of Śrī Kṛṣṇa."

71 He asked, "Who is a Vaiṣṇava? What are his marks?" Then the Lord, knowing his mind, smiled and said,

72 "One in whose mouth the Name of Kṛṣṇa is always present is the best of Vaiṣṇavas. Worship his feet."

73 A year later they asked the same question again, and the Lord taught them the gradation of Vaiṣṇavas:

74 "One whose very sight brings the Name of Kṛṣṇa to the mouth — know him to be the foremost Vaiṣṇava."

75 Step by step the Lord described the marks of a Vaiṣṇava: the Vaiṣṇava, the higher Vaiṣṇava (*vaiṣṇavatara*) and the highest Vaiṣṇava (*vaiṣṇavatama*).

76 In this way all the Vaiṣṇavas returned to Gauḍa. That year Vidyānidhi stayed on in Nīlādri.

77 He had a loving friendship with Svarūpa, and the two of them stayed together, absorbed in talks about Kṛṣṇa.

78 He gave the *mantra* to Gadādhara Paṇḍita a second time, and he saw the festival on the day of Oḍana-ṣaṣṭhī.

79 There Jagannātha is dressed in starched (*māḍuyā*) cloth, and when Vidyānidhi saw this, he felt disgust.

80 That night Jagannātha and Balāi came to him, and the two brothers slapped him, laughing all the while.

81 His cheeks swelled, but the Ācārya rejoiced at heart. Vṛndāvana dāsa has described this in detail.

82 In this way the devotees of Gauḍa came every year, stayed with the Lord and saw the festival.

83 Whatever was special in particular years, I shall relate fully and in detail later on.

84 So four years of Mahāprabhu's life passed. Going south and coming back took two years.

85 For another two years He wanted to go to Vṛndāvana, but because of Rāmānanda's insistence the Lord could not set out.

86 In the fifth year the devotees of Gauḍa came; they saw the Ratha-yātrā, but they did not stay and returned to Gauḍa.

87 Then the Lord embraced Sārvabhauma and Rāmānanda and spoke to them sweetly:

88 “I am very eager to go to Vṛndāvana. Because of your insistence I have not gone for two years.

89 I shall certainly go now — both of you, give your consent. I have no refuge but you two.

90 In Gauḍa-deśa I have two shelters, My mother and the Jāhnavī (Gaṅgā); both are all-merciful.

91 I shall go by way of Gauḍa-deśa and see them both. Be pleased, both of you, and give Me leave.”

92 Hearing the Lord’s words, they reflected: “To insist too much with the Lord is never good.”

93 They both said, “Now it is the rainy season; You cannot travel. When Vijayā-daśamī comes, You shall certainly go.”

94 Mahāprabhu happily saw the rainy season through, and on the day of Vijayā-daśamī He set out.

95 He took with Him all the *prasāda* of Jagannātha that He had received — *kaḍāra* ointment, sandalwood paste and ropes.

96 He begged leave of Jagannātha and set out at dawn, and the Oḍiyā devotees came following behind Him.

97 With some effort the Lord made the Oḍiyā devotees turn back, and with His own associates He came to Bhavānīpura.

98 Rāmānanda came after Him, riding in a palanquin, and Vāṇīnātha sent a great deal of *prasāda*.

99 After taking the *prasāda* He stayed there, and setting out in the morning, the Lord came to Bhuvaneśvara.

100 Coming to Kaṭaka, He had *darśana* of Gopāla, and the brāhmaṇa Svapneśvara invited the Lord for a meal.

101 Rāmānanda Rāya invited all the associates, and the Lord came to a garden outside the town and stayed there.

102 After His meal He rested under a *bakula* tree, and Rāmānanda Rāya went to Pratāparudra.

103 Delighted at the news, the king came at once, and seeing the Lord, he fell flat on the ground like a rod.

104 Overwhelmed by love, he rose and fell again and again; he offered prayers, the hair of his body stood on end, and tears flowed from his eyes.

105 Seeing his devotion, the Lord was pleased at heart. Mahāprabhu rose and embraced him.

106 Again the king offered prayers and bowed down, and his body was bathed in tears of the Lord’s mercy.

107 Rāmānanda calmed the king and seated him, and the Lord showed him mercy in body, mind and words.

108 Gaurarāya showed him such mercy that He came to be called “the Saviour of Pratāparudra.”

109 The king’s ministers paid homage to the Lord, and Śacī’s son gave the king leave to go.

110 Coming outside, the king had an order drawn up and sent it to all the revenue officers (*viṣayī*) of his kingdom:

111 “In every village build new lodgings; fill five or seven houses with all provisions.

112 Bring the Lord there yourselves and lodge Him there, and stay in His service night and day, cane in hand.”

113 The king gave this order to two of his chief ministers, Haricandana and Maṅgarāja: “See to everything.

114 Bring a new boat and keep it at the river bank where the Lord will bathe and cross the river.

115 There erect a pillar, making it a great *tīrtha*. Bathe there every day — and may I leave my body there.

116 Build excellent new lodgings in Caturdvāra. And you, Rāmānanda, go to Mahāprabhu.”

117 The king heard that the Lord would set out in the evening, and he had the women of the palace seated in tents on the backs of elephants.

118 They stood in a row along the road the Lord was to take, and in the evening the Lord set out with His associates.

119 Coming to the river Citrotpalā, He bathed at the *ghāṭ*, and all the queens watched Him and bowed down.

120 At the sight of the Lord they were all filled with love; they cried “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!” and tears streamed from their eyes.

121 Nowhere in the three worlds have I heard of one so merciful: love for Kṛṣṇa awakens even in those who see Him from afar.

122 The Lord boarded the boat and crossed the river, and travelling on through the moonlit night He came to Caturdvāra.

123 He stayed there that night and bathed in the morning. Just then Jagannātha’s *mahā-prasāda* arrived.

124 By the king’s order the *paḍichā* sent *prasāda* day after day — a great quantity of it, carried by many people.

125 The Lord accepted the *prasāda* with His associates, then rose and set out, calling “Hari! Hari!”

126 Rāmānanda, Maṅgarāja and Śrī Haricandana — these three went along with Him, serving Him.

127–129 With the Lord were Purī Gosāñi, Svarūpa Dāmodara, Jagadānanda, Mukunda, Govinda, Kāśīśvara, Haridāsa Ṭhākura, Vakreśvara Paṇḍita, Gopīnāthācārya, Dāmodara Paṇḍita, Rāmāi, Nandāi and many other devotees. I have named only the chief among them — who can count them all?

130 When Gadādhara Paṇḍita set out with them, the Lord forbade him: “Do not give up your *kṣetra-sannyāsa*.”

131 The Paṇḍita said, “Wherever You are, that is Nīlācala. Let my *kṣetra-sannyāsa* go to Rasātala!”

132 The Lord said, “Stay here and serve Gopīnātha.” The Paṇḍita said, “Seeing Your feet is worth ten million services.”

133 The Lord said, “If you give up the service, the fault will fall on Me. Stay here and serve — that will please Me.”

134 The Paṇḍita said, “All the fault will be upon me. I shall not go with You; I shall go alone.

135 I shall go to see Āi (Mother Śacī), not for Your sake. The fault of giving up my vow and my service — that I shall bear myself.”

136 Saying this, Paṇḍita Gosāñi travelled on separately. When the Lord reached Kaṭaka, He had him brought to Him.

137 The Paṇḍita’s love for Gaurāṅga is beyond understanding: he gave up his vow and the service of Śrī Kṛṣṇa as though they were a blade of grass.

138 Inwardly the Lord was pleased with his conduct, but He took him by the hand and spoke with loving anger:

139 “Giving up your vow and your service — that was your aim, and it has been accomplished: you have left them and come to a distant land.

140 You want to stay with Me — you are seeking your own happiness. But you are losing both your duties, and that makes Me sad.

141 If you want My happiness, go back to Nīlācala. I adjure you by Myself — do not say another word.”

142 Saying this, Mahāprabhu got into the boat, and the Paṇḍita fell there unconscious.

143 The Lord ordered Sārvabhauma to take the Paṇḍita back with him. The Bhaṭṭācārya said, “Get up — such is the Lord’s *līlā*.

144 You know that Kṛṣṇa gave up His own vow; compelled by mercy for His devotee, He kept Bhīṣma’s vow.

145 “To make my promise true, He gave up His own: He leapt down from the chariot, took up a chariot wheel and rushed at me like a lion going to kill an elephant, so that the earth trembled, and His upper cloth fell away” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.9.37).

146 “In the same way the Lord endured separation from you and took great pains to protect your vow.”

147 Speaking in this way, he consoled him, and the two of them, stricken with grief, came back to Nīlācala.

148 For the Lord’s sake the devotees give up their religious duties and works, yet the Lord cannot bear to see a devotee’s duty suffer.

149 These are the strange turns of love (*premera vivarta*). Whoever hears of them will soon attain the feet of Śrī Caitanya.

150 When the Lord came to Yājapura, He bade farewell to the two royal officers who were travelling with Him.

151 The Lord sent them back, but Rāya went on with Him, and night and day the Lord talked of Kṛṣṇa with Rāmānanda.

152 In every village, by the king's order, the king's servants served Him with a new house and all kinds of provisions.

153 Travelling in this way, the Lord came to Remuṇā, and from there He sent Rāmānanda Rāya back.

154 Rāya fell to the ground unconscious, and the Lord took him on His lap and wept.

155 Rāya's grief at parting was unbearable; I cannot describe it.

156 Then the Lord came to the border of the land of Oḍhra, and there the king's governor met Him.

157 He served the Lord for a few days and then explained to Him what lay ahead on the road.

158 "Ahead lies the domain of a drunken *yavana* king. For fear of him no one can travel this road.

159 "All the land as far as Picchaladā is his, and for fear of him no one can cross the river.

160 "Stay here a few days. I will make a truce with him, and then I will send You on comfortably by boat."

161 At that time one of that *yavana*'s men came to the Oriyā camp in disguise.

162 Seeing the Lord's wonderful ways, the Hindu spy went back to the *yavana* and said,

163 “A *sannyāsī* has come from Jagannātha, and many perfected souls are with Him.

164 “All of them constantly perform the *saṅkīrtana* of Kṛṣṇa; they all laugh, dance, sing and weep.

165 “Hundreds of thousands of people come to see it, and once they have seen Him, they cannot go home again.

166 “All those people become like madmen: crying ‘Kṛṣṇa!’, they dance, weep and roll on the ground.

167 “It is not something one can describe; one knows it only by seeing it. By His power I accept Him as God (*Īśvara*).”

168 Saying this, the spy himself began to sing “Hari! Kṛṣṇa!”, laughing, weeping, dancing and singing like a madman.

169 Hearing this, the *yavana*’s heart turned, and he sent his own secretary (*viśvāsa*) to the Oriyā officer.

170 The secretary came and bowed at the Lord’s feet, and, crying “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!”, he was overwhelmed with love.

171 Composing himself, he bowed to the Oriyā officer and said, “The *mleccha* governor has sent me to you.

172 “If you give permission, the *yavana* governor will come here, meet the Lord and go back.

173 “He is very eager and has asked most humbly. This is a truce with you; there need be no fear of war.”

174 Hearing this, the Mahāpātra was amazed and said, “Who could make the heart of a drunken *yavana* like this?

175 “Mahāprabhu Himself has turned his mind — He by the sight and remembrance of whom the whole world is delivered.”

176 Saying this, he told the secretary, “It is his good fortune. Let him come and see the Lord.

177 “I will trust him if he comes unarmed, bringing only five or seven servants with him.”

178 The secretary went and told him everything, and the *yavana* came dressed as a Hindu.

179 Seeing the Lord from afar, he fell to the ground in prostrate obeisance, in tears and with his hair standing on end.

180 The Mahāpātra brought him forward with honour, and with joined palms he chanted the name of Kṛṣṇa before the Lord:

181 “Why was I born in a low *yavana* family? Why did Providence not have me born in a Hindu family?

182 “Had I been a Hindu, I would have gained a place near Your feet. This body of mine is useless — let my life go!”

183 Hearing this, the Mahāpātra was overwhelmed with feeling; clasping the Lord’s feet, he praised Him:

184 “By hearing Your holy name even a *caṇḍāla* becomes pure — and this soul has gained the sight of such a Lord as You!

185 “What wonder is there in his coming to such a state? Such is the power of seeing You.

186 “O Lord, by hearing and chanting Your name, by bowing to You or even by remembering You only once, even a dog-eater at once becomes fit to perform Vedic sacrifice. How much more, then, by seeing You!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 3.33.6)

187 Then Mahāprabhu cast a merciful glance on him and, reassuring him, said, “Chant ‘Kṛṣṇa’ and ‘Hari’.”

188 He said, “If You have accepted me, give me one order, so that I may serve You.

189 “I have done endless violence to cows, brāhmaṇas and Vaiṣṇavas. May I be delivered from that sin.”

190 Then Mukunda Datta said, “Listen, good sir: Mahāprabhu wishes to go to the bank of the Gaṅgā.

191 “Help Him in some way to get there. That is the great order; that will be the great service.”

192 Then he bowed at Mahāprabhu’s feet, bowed at the feet of all, and went away rejoicing.

193 The Mahāpātra embraced him and, giving him many gifts, made friends with him.

194 In the morning he fitted out many boats and sent his secretary to bring the Lord.

195 The Mahāpātra came along with Mahāprabhu, and the *mleccha* came and worshipped the Lord’s feet.

196 There was one new boat with a cabin in the middle, and the Lord went on board with His companions.

197 Mahāprabhu bade the Mahāpātra farewell, and he stood on the bank, weeping and weeping, gazing after Him.

198 For fear of river pirates the *yavana* went along too, taking many soldiers with him in ten boats.

199 He brought them across the dangerous Mantreśvara river, and the *yavana* came with them all the way to Picchaldā.

200 From that village the Lord bade him farewell. I cannot describe the signs of love he showed then.

201 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya performs pastimes beyond this world. Whoever hears of them is blessed in his birth and in his body.

202 Riding in that boat, the Lord came to Pāṇihāṭi, and He clothed the boatman in the cloth of His own mercy.

203 “The Lord has come!” — a great clamour rose among the people, and everything, water and land alike, was filled with people.

204 Rāghava Paṇḍita came and took the Lord with him, but because of the crowds on the way they got there only with great difficulty.

205 The Lord stayed there one day, and in the morning He came to Kumārahaṭṭa, where Śrīnivāsa lived.

206 From there He went on to Śivānanda's house, and after that the Lord came to the house of Vāsudeva.

207 Then came the Lord's stay in Vācaspati's house, and His going to Kuliyā for fear of the crowds.

208 There the son of Śacī stayed in the house of Mādhava dāsa, and countless millions of people had His *darśana*.

209 He stayed there seven days and delivered the people; in His own way He saved even all the offenders.

210 In the same way He came to the house of the Ācārya of Śāntipura, and meeting Mother Śacī, He dispelled her sorrow.

211 Then came the Lord's going to the village of Rāmakeli, and His turning back again from Nāṭaśālā.

212 In Śāntipura He stayed again for ten days. Vṛndāvana dāsa has described all this in detail.

213 Therefore I have not described it at length here: it would be a repetition, and the book would grow endlessly.

214 Among these events are how Rūpa and Sanātana met Him, and how Nṛsiṁhānanda decorated the road for Him.

215 I have already described these pastimes in the summary, so I have not written of them here again.

216 When the Lord came to Śāntipura once again, Raghunātha dāsa came and met Him.

217 Hiraṇya and Govardhana were two brothers, masters of twelve lakhs of coins in Saptagrāma.

218 Both were immensely wealthy, generous and devoted to brāhmaṇas; they were men of good conduct and noble family, counted foremost among the righteous.

219 They were almost the sole support of the brāhmaṇas of Nadīyā, helping them with gifts of money, land and villages.

220 Nīlāmbara Cakravartī was revered by both of them, and the Cakravartī treated them as his brothers.

221 In the past they had served Miśra Purandara, and so the Lord knew them both well.

222 Raghunātha dāsa was the son of that Govardhana. From childhood he was indifferent to worldly things.

223 When the Lord came to Śāntipura after taking *sannyāsa*, Raghunātha had come and met Him.

224 Absorbed in love, he fell at the Lord’s feet, and the Lord mercifully touched him with His foot.

225 His father always served the Ācārya, and so the Ācārya was gracious to him.

226 By the Ācārya’s grace he received the Lord’s plate of remnants, and for five or seven days he saw the Lord’s feet.

227 The Lord bade him farewell and went to Nīlācala, and he came home mad with love.

228 Again and again he ran away to go to Nīlādri, and his father would bring him back from the road and keep him bound.

229 Five guards watched him night and day, and four servants and two brāhmaṇas stayed with him.

230 Eleven people guarded him constantly. He could not go to Nīlācala, and his heart was full of sorrow.

231 Now, hearing that Mahāprabhu had come to Śāntipura, Raghunātha humbly said to his father,

232 “Give me leave to go and see the Lord’s feet; otherwise my life will not stay in my body.”

233 Hearing this, his father gave him many men and provisions and sent him off, saying, “Come back quickly.”

234 For seven days he stayed with the Lord in Śāntipura, and night and day he spoke the thought of his heart:

235 “How shall I escape from the hands of my guards? How shall I go to Nīlācala with the Lord?”

236 The omniscient Lord Gaurāṅga knew his mind, and in the form of instruction He spoke words of comfort to him:

237 “Be steady and go home; do not act like a madman. Step by step a person reaches the shore of the ocean of material existence.

238 “Do not make a show of monkey renunciation (*markaṭa-vairāgya*) for people to see. Accept worldly things as is fitting, but without attachment.

239 “Keep firm faith within, and outwardly behave as people do in the world. Very soon Kṛṣṇa will deliver you.

240 “When I have seen Vṛndāvana and come back to Nīlācala, then come to Me on some pretext.

241 “At that time Kṛṣṇa Himself will show you that pretext. Who can hold back one who has Kṛṣṇa’s mercy?”

242 Saying this, Mahāprabhu bade him farewell, and he went home and followed Mahāprabhu’s teaching.

243 Giving up all his outward renunciation and madness, he did his duties as was fitting, without attachment.

244 Seeing this, his father and mother were very happy, and the watch over him was somewhat relaxed.

245 Here, meanwhile, the Lord gathered all the devotees together — Advaita, Nityānanda and all the others —

246 and, embracing them all, the Lord said, “All of you, give Me leave to go to Nīlācala.

247 “I have met all of you here. This year let no one go to Nīlādri.

248 “From there I shall certainly go to Vṛndāvana. Give Me your leave, all of you, and then I shall come back without any obstacle.”

249 Clasping His mother’s feet, He entreated her humbly and received her permission to go to Vṛndāvana.

250 Then He sent her back to Navadvīpa and set out for Nīlādri, taking devotees with Him.

251 All those people served Him along the way, and the son of Śacī came happily to Nīlācala.

252 On arriving, the Lord went to see Jagannātha, and the town was in an uproar: “Mahāprabhu has come!”

253 The delighted devotees came to meet Him, and the Lord embraced them all with love.

254 Kāśī Miśra, Rāmānanda, Pradyumna, Sārvabhauma, Vāṇīnātha, Śikhi and all the other devotees came.

255 Gadādhara Paṇḍita came and met the Lord, and in front of them all the Lord began to speak:

256 “I thought, ‘I shall go to Vṛndāvana through the land of Gauḍa, seeing on the way the feet of My mother and of the Gaṅgā.’

257 “With this resolve I set out for Gauḍa, and about a thousand of My own devotees came along with Me.

258 “Hundreds of thousands of people came to see the spectacle, and in the crush of people I could not travel the road.

259 “Wherever I stayed, houses and walls were crushed; wherever My eyes fell, I saw the place filled with people.

260 “With great difficulty I reached the village of Rāmakeli. There two men named Rūpa and Sanātana came to Me.

261 “The two brothers are kings among devotees, vessels of Kṛṣṇa’s mercy; in worldly affairs they are the king’s ministers and high officers.

262 “In learning, devotion, intelligence and strength they are supremely accomplished, yet they consider themselves lower than a blade of grass.

263 “Seeing and hearing their humility, even a stone would break. Pleased with them, I said to them both,

264 “ ‘Though you are exalted, you consider yourselves low. Kṛṣṇa will soon deliver you.’

265 “When I had said this and bade them farewell, Sanātana spoke a riddle as I was leaving:

266 “ ‘For one who has hundreds of thousands, even millions of people with Him, this is not the proper way to go to Vṛndāvana.’

267 “Yet I only heard it and paid it no heed. In the morning I set out and came to the village of Kānāira Nāṭaśālā.

268 “At night I thought over in My mind what riddle it was that Sanātana had told Me.

269 “He spoke well. I have so many people with Me; seeing this, people will say of Me, ‘This is just a show!’

270 “That Vṛndāvana is rare, hard to reach and solitary. I shall go alone, or with just one companion.

271 “Mādhavendra Purī went there alone, and on the pretext of bringing him milk, Kṛṣṇa appeared to him in person.

272 “I set out for there like a juggler staging his show. One does not go to Vṛndāvana with a crowd.

273 “I shall go alone, or with just one servant; only then is a journey to Vṛndāvana as it should be.

274 “I was to go to Vṛndāvana alone — and here I have set out with an army, beating drums!

275 “Saying ‘Shame, shame on Me!’, I grew restless, and turning back, I came again to the bank of the Gaṅgā.

276 “I left the devotees in their various places and came back; only five or six people came with Me.

277 “Now, how am I to go to Vṛndāvana without obstacles? All of you together, be gracious and give Me your counsel.

278 “I went away leaving Gadādhara behind, and he was grieved. For that reason I could not go to Vṛndāvana.”

279 Then Gadādhara Paṇḍita, absorbed in love, clasped the Lord’s feet and humbly said,

280 “Wherever You stay, there is Vṛndāvana, and there are the Yamunā, the Gaṅgā and all the holy places.

281 “Still, You go to Vṛndāvana to teach people. You will do just what Your heart decides.

282 “Lord, the four months of the rains are almost upon us. Spend these four months in Nīlācala.

283 “Afterwards do whatever You have in mind. Go or stay as You please — who could stop You?”

284 Hearing this, all the devotees said at the Lord’s feet, “The Paṇḍita has put forward what we all desire.”

285 At everyone’s wish the Lord stayed for the four months, and when Pratāparudra heard this, he was delighted.

286 That day Gadādhara invited Him, and the Lord took His meal there with the devotees.

287 The Paṇḍita’s affection at that meal and the Lord’s relishing of it — neither can be described by human power.

288 Such are Gaura’s pastimes, endless and boundless. I tell them in brief, for they cannot be told in full.

289 Ananta Himself tells of them with His thousand mouths, yet He cannot reach the end of even one pastime.

290 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.